

War of the VETERANS

The charismatic Dikshit's bid for an unprecedented third term faces a tough challenge from battle-scarred Malhotra



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By Priya Sahgal

Every Tuesday Delhi's Chief Minister Sheila Dikshit throws open the lawns of her house to schoolchildren where the flora and the fauna are neatly labelled with their Latin names. Even though it was on the eve of a crucial election, Dikshit kept her date with the children last week as she walked through her garden. Pointing to the bats asleep in the trees, she said, "They'll come out at night." A decade in power has made Delhi's longest serving chief minister rather familiar with stealth attacks, having faced more than her share of them by her own party men. As recently as six months ago, she was rocked by

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Congress has retained 40 of its 47 sitting MLAs while BJP has fielded all 19. It has fielded eight women candidates compared to BJP's three.

rumours that the Congress may change its chief minister. An internal party poll, however, revealed that the white-haired, 70-year-old Dikshit still remained the party's best face. At 4 feet 11 inches, she overshadowed Congressmen as ambitious but less charismatic as her.

"It is not correct that I am larger than the Congress. I am with the party," said Dikshit. She is with the Congress and so has to say that. But ask the BJP and it admits that its main challenge was to find someone who could dent her appeal. Finally, it opted for performance over charisma and chose the four-term Lok Sabha winner V.K. Malhotra. His checked suits